White House has no good midterm disruption options

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White House has no good options for midterm disruptions

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President Donald Trump’s administration does not have credible options to overturn or otherwise reverse the results of either the House or Senate elections if Democrats win majorities in either chamber in November.
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The most concerning development would be a serious attempt by Republican elected officials to deny election results or certifications in close House races to avoid seating Democratic winners, though an expected wide Democratic margin of victory for Democrats makes this tactic implausible.
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Vote-counting delays, recounts, and legal challenges are normal parts of the election process and should not provoke concern about the conduct of the elections.

Eurasia Group does not expect serious disruptions to the midterm elections. Concerns that the Trump administration might meddle with the midterms, whether before or after the vote, have proliferated in recent months. Those fears are not ill-founded. Trump attempted to keep control of the White House after losing the 2020 election, and he recently backed a crackdown on mail-in voting that the courts blocked. But we do not expect the administration to try to subvert the results this year, and we think it would fail if it did.

The Department of Justice’s suits in California and Alaska are emblematic: With essentially no chance of either suit blocking certification of the elections, they are more geared toward creating a post-election narrative of illegitimacy than toward actually preventing Democrats from taking power (see “DOJ election suits aim to create illegitimacy narrative ,” US Daily, 26 October 2026).

A serious attempt by current elected officials to deny House election results or certification would be the most concerning development. If governors or secretaries of state withhold certification of elections in close Democratic wins, congressional Republicans could try to refuse to seat lawfully elected Democratic members when the House convenes on 3 January 2027. Another warning sign would be competing slates of election victors from one state—analogous to the fake electors scheme in 2020—or the outright

defiance of court orders requiring certification. The goal would likely be to exploit a constitutional loophole to compel the House clerk to deny seats to members in contested races on 3 January.

Vote delays, recounts, and legal challenges are normal parts of the election process. The proliferation of mail-in voting in recent years has exacerbated some states' issues with counting ballots quickly; races there could drag on well into November, with leads changing as ballots are counted. Some candidates may delay their concessions until after election day. Legal challenges, particularly over provisional ballots, are likely, as are recounts in close races. None of these are signals of subversion.

More concerning activity would involve attempts to disqualify large swathes of mail-in ballots; the presence of federal law enforcement at election sites, even if ostensibly neutral; any moves by county election boards to deny or delay certification of results; or federal moves in the final days of the campaign against mail-in ballots or voting machines. In all of these cases, we believe near-certain court pushback would be effective.

Politics is just as great a check as are institutions. In addition to likely pushback from the courts, which we expect would be effective, we see three major political reasons why election meddling is unlikely:

1.
Democrats are likely to have a large enough majority in the House. The most plausible scheme for denying Democrats a majority would involve contesting elections at the state level and refusing to seat those members while the matter is resolved, similar to the 1985 dispute of a close House election in Indiana. That strategy works only if Democrats win by a few seats, not by the more than 20-seat margin we currently expect. In that case, Republicans would need to keep contestations going well past their normal timeline in over two dozen districts to deny a majority.
2.
Trump doesn't care. Trump has been notably unconcerned about losing Republican majorities. He sees Congress as having fulfilled his political ends and will govern via executive powers after the midterms. Unlike a presidential election, in which his own personal standing is at stake, losing Congress would not push him to embark on a risky and ultimately fruitless path of election contestation.
3.
Republicans won't go along with it. Republicans have a thin majority as it stands; we believe that resistance in the party to obvious attempts to overturn election results would not receive enough support in the party to be viable.

Claims of a stolen election will serve Trump in his effort to remake the GOP. Just as aligning with Trump's view that the 2020 election was stolen from him has become a standard loyalty test, claims that Democrats "stole" the midterms will become a tool for Trump to use in his efforts to remake the Republican Party in his image over the next two years (see "Trump's executive actions and legacy-building will dominate post-midterms ," 3 June 2026). The purpose they serve will be more rhetorical than substantive and will—like the 2020 election claims—compress the available space for non-MAGA voices in the party.

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